

LSO 100 - The Canadian Short Story

Week 10-Memory, Loss, and Nostalgia

Alistair MacLeod's "The Closing Down of Summer"

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Why Do We Remember?

A Question Worth Asking

Have you ever looked back at a place, a tradition, or a period in your life and realized it no longer exists in the same way? A neighbourhood changed, a family tradition faded, a workplace that once seemed permanent disappeared. Memory allows us to revisit those experiences – but it also reminds us that time brings irreversible change.

This Week's Inquiry

Through MacLeod's "The Closing Down of Summer," we explore how memory becomes a means of preserving experiences, values, and identities that might otherwise be lost. As you read, consider: What experiences have shaped who you are? Which stories have been passed down in your family? How do people preserve important memories when the world changes around them?

Cape Breton

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Alistair MacLeod & Cape Breton

Widely regarded as one of Canada's most accomplished short-story writers, MacLeod devoted his literary life to the people and communities of Cape Breton, Nova Scotia. His stories focus on families, labour, migration, tradition, and the powerful bonds connecting individuals to place and history. His celebrated collection *Island: The Complete Stories* (2000) stands as a landmark of Canadian literature, documenting a world shaped by the sea, the land, and the mine.



A Story About More Than Mining

The Surface Reading

At first glance, the story follows miners returning to work after a summer spent with their families – travelling great distances to face dangerous conditions underground, separated for months from home and community.

The Deeper Story

Through the narrator's reflections, MacLeod explores the emotional realities of a life shaped by labour, family responsibility, and tradition. Mining is not simply a job; it is a family history and a cultural heritage stretching back through generations.

The Central Question

What happens to identity when a way of life begins to disappear? The story asks how individuals find meaning when the structures that defined them – the mine, the community, the tradition – are slowly closing down.

Identity is often inherited through stories, traditions, and shared experiences – rather than created entirely on our own.

One of the story's most powerful moments occurs when the narrator reflects on how many generations of his family have worked in mines. These memories connect him to people he may never have known personally, yet whose experiences continue to shape his understanding of himself.



THEME 1

Memory and Family History

Memory serves as the **foundation of the narrator's identity**. Throughout the story, he constantly looks backward, connecting his present experiences to the lives of earlier generations. His memories are not isolated personal recollections – they are part of a larger family narrative.

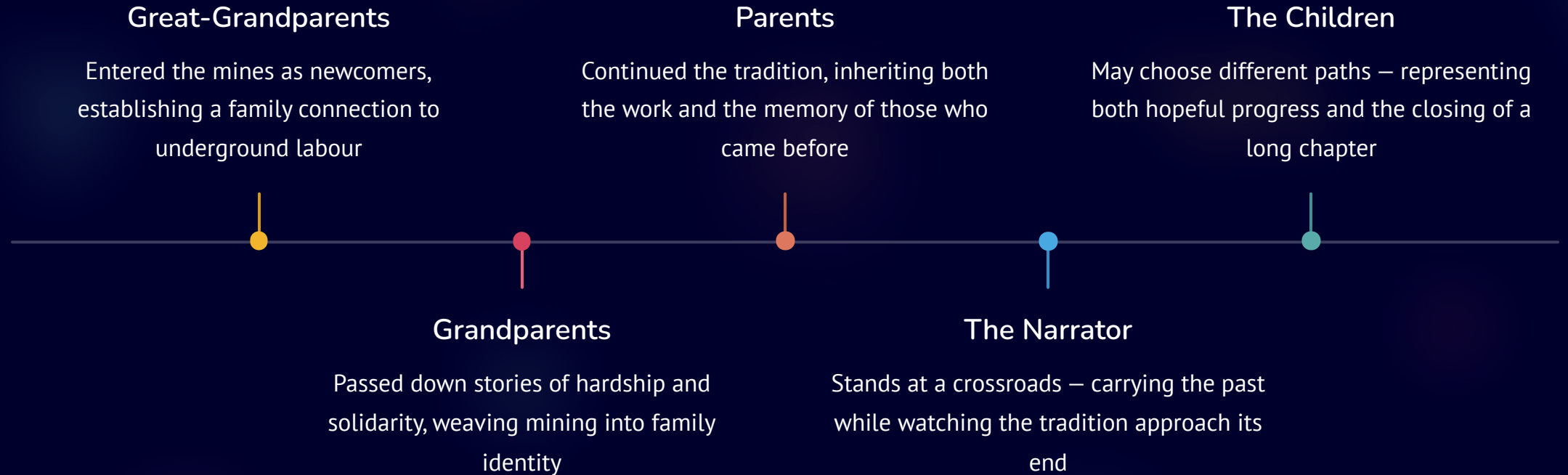
He remembers ancestors who worked under dangerous conditions and accepted hardship as part of everyday life. These memories create a sense of **continuity between the past and the present**, situating the narrator within a chain of experiences stretching across generations.

Memory Is More Than Fact

MacLeod demonstrates that memory is not simply about recording events. Memory *gives meaning* to experiences. Through remembering, individuals create connections between past and present, allowing family histories to remain alive even as outward circumstances change.

❏ Consider: Many people know stories about grandparents or great-grandparents they never met. How do those inherited stories influence how your family understands itself?

The Chain of Generations



This generational chain is not merely biographical – it is the structural backbone of the narrator's identity. Each link in the chain preserves the meaning of the one before it.



THEME 2

Work, Sacrifice, and Identity

For the narrator and his fellow miners, work is not simply a source of income. It shapes their daily lives, their relationships, and their deepest sense of purpose. The miners spend long periods away from their families, travelling to distant locations where they face genuinely dangerous conditions – sacrifices that remain largely invisible to the outside world.

The Emotional Cost of Labour

Physical Danger

Underground mining carries constant risk of injury and death. The miners accept these conditions not with resignation but with a practised, inherited courage passed down through generations.

Family Separation

Months spent away from spouses and children create wounds that are rarely spoken about. MacLeod renders visible the private grief of men who love their families but must leave to sustain them.

Hope and Sadness

The narrator hopes his children will find safer, better opportunities – yet this very hope carries a deep sadness. If they choose different paths, a tradition that has lasted generations may quietly come to an end.

📄 This tension is one of the story's most important themes: progress often brings genuine opportunities, but it can also mean the loss of traditions and identities that have long provided meaning and connection.

THEME 3

Understanding Different Forms of Loss

When we think of loss, we often think of death. But MacLeod presents loss as a far more varied and pervasive experience – one that touches time, tradition, community, and certainty itself.



Loss of Time

The narrator recognizes with quiet urgency that he is growing older and that the years are passing more quickly than he can account for.



Loss of Tradition

The mining culture that shaped previous generations is gradually disappearing – not through any single event, but through the accumulation of small departures.



Loss of Community

Economic and social changes have altered the structures that once brought people together, fraying the bonds that defined belonging.



Loss of Certainty

Earlier generations expected their children to follow similar paths. Modern life offers many alternatives – creating both freedom and a new kind of uncertainty.

Change Brings Both Gains and Losses



**Safety for future generations,
new opportunities,
wider horizons,
personal freedom.**



**End of family tradition,
loss of community identity,
disappearance of shared cultural practices,
fading of inherited knowledge.**

The story never presents change as simply positive or simply negative. MacLeod insists on complexity: the same developments that bring safety and opportunity also dissolve the traditions and bonds that gave people their deepest sense of meaning.



THEME 4

Nostalgia: More Than Simple Longing

Nostalgia is often defined as a longing for the past. But MacLeod presents something far more nuanced and honest. The narrator does not pretend the past was perfect — he remembers dangerous working conditions, physical exhaustion, painful family separations, and economic hardship. And yet, he remains deeply emotionally connected to the world that shaped him.

His nostalgia is not based on fantasy. It reflects an appreciation for the values, relationships, and sense of belonging that characterized his community — even amid its difficulties.

Nostalgia as Complexity

What Nostalgia Is *Not*

- A belief that the past was perfect
- A refusal to accept change
- Simple sentimentality or wishful thinking
- A retreat from the present

What Nostalgia *Is* in This Story

- An honest appreciation for what was genuinely meaningful
- A recognition that relationships and traditions had real value
- A way of honouring people whose sacrifices shaped the present
- Both comforting and painful at once

The story demonstrates that nostalgia can celebrate meaningful experiences while simultaneously reminding us that those experiences cannot be fully recovered.

THEME 5

Storytelling as Cultural Preservation

Throughout the story, storytelling functions as a form of active resistance against forgetting. The narrator's memories keep alive the experiences of earlier generations and ensure that their lives continue to have meaning. Without stories, much of history would simply vanish – families preserve traditions through stories, communities maintain cultural identity through stories, and nations remember important events through stories.



MacLeod and Canadian Literary Tradition

An Act of Resistance

In "The Closing Down of Summer," storytelling becomes an act of resistance against erasure. Even if future generations never work in mines, they can still understand the experiences of those who did – through stories like this one. The narrator's reflections preserve a way of life that is gradually disappearing.

A Broader Canadian Conversation

This impulse is central to Canadian literature more broadly. Many Canadian writers explore how storytelling helps preserve regional cultures, Indigenous traditions, immigrant experiences, and community histories. MacLeod's work contributes to this tradition by documenting the lives and memories of **Atlantic Canadian communities** with rare specificity and emotional depth.

THEME 6

Place, Community, and Belonging

The narrator's memories are inseparable from the landscapes and communities of Cape Breton. For many people, identity is tied not only to family but to specific places – certain landscapes, buildings, workplaces, and neighbourhoods become anchored to personal memories. When those places change or disappear, individuals may feel as though part of their own identity has been altered as well.

As economic changes transform his community, the narrator experiences both **pride in what the future may bring** and genuine grief for what is being irrevocably lost.



Why This Story Still Matters Today



Industries Decline

Communities built around specific industries continue to face transformation, closure, and reinvention across Canada and the world.



Generations Diverge

Younger generations pursue different opportunities, relocate, and build lives that may have little outward resemblance to those of their parents and grandparents.



Communities Evolve

New technologies alter how people work and communicate, reshaping what community means and where belonging is found.



Emotions Endure

Pride, uncertainty, nostalgia, hope, and loss continue to resonate because they reflect the universal experience of living through change.

LEARNING ACTIVITY 1

Memory and Identity Map

The Task

Create a visual or written "**Memory and Identity Map**" for the narrator of "The Closing Down of Summer."

Identify **at least five** memories, traditions, or experiences mentioned in the story and explain how each contributes to the narrator's sense of identity.

Length: Approximately 250–300 words.

Guiding Questions

- What specific memory or tradition have you identified?
- How does it connect the narrator to family, community, or cultural heritage?
- What does it reveal about how he understands himself?
- Does it involve pride, grief, ambivalence – or all three?
- How does this memory relate to others you have identified?

For each example, include a brief explanation of what it reveals about family, work, community, or cultural heritage. Think of your map as tracing the architecture of a single person's identity.

LEARNING ACTIVITY 2

Change, Loss, and Community Reflection

Think about a community, workplace, family tradition, neighbourhood, or cultural practice that has changed significantly over time. In a short reflection, compare that example to the changes represented in "The Closing Down of Summer."

1

What Has Changed?

Describe the transformation clearly. What does this community, tradition, or place look like today compared to how it once appeared?

2

What Has Been Gained?

Consider the genuine benefits that change has brought. What opportunities, freedoms, or improvements have emerged from this transformation?

3

What Has Been Lost?

Identify what has been left behind – traditions, relationships, forms of knowledge, or sources of meaning that no longer exist in the same way.

4

Emotional Responses

How do people respond emotionally to these changes? Consider the range of reactions – from grief and nostalgia to relief, ambivalence, and hope.

Length: Approximately 300–400 words.

REFERENCES

Further Reading



Primary Text

MacLeod, A. (2000). "The Closing Down of Summer." In *Island: The Complete Stories*. McClelland & Stewart.

Online Resources

The Canadian Encyclopedia – [Cape Breton Island](#)

The Canadian Encyclopedia – [Coal Mining in Canada](#)

The Canadian Encyclopedia – Alistair MacLeod

Anthology

Brown, R. (Ed.). *An Anthology of Canadian Literature in English*. Oxford University Press.